"I'm dumb."

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Struggles with reading, math, attention, or processing can bring years of corrections, low grades, and comparisons. Labels like "slow" or "lazy" stick, and many carry the word "dumb" into adulthood.

What Scripture teaches

"God chose the foolish things of the world to shame the wise; God chose the weak things of the world to shame the strong." "Not many of you were wise by human standards." Peter and John were "unschooled, ordinary men" whose boldness amazed people because "they had been with Jesus" (Acts 4:13). God gives each person different gifts, and "to each one the manifestation of the Spirit is given for the common good." Learning differences are real, and they say nothing about your worth or your intelligence in other areas.

> *"But God chose the foolish things of the world to shame the wise; God chose the weak things of the world to shame the strong"* (1 Corinthians 1:27).

Also see

> "Now to each one the manifestation of the Spirit is given for the common good" (1 Corinthians 12:7).

> "When they saw the boldness of Peter and John and realized that they were unschooled, ordinary men, they marveled and took note that these men had been with Jesus" (Acts 4:13).

> "I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well" (Psalm 139:14).

> "Just as each of us has one body with many members, and not all members have the same function, so in Christ we who are many are one body, and each member belongs to one another. We have different gifts according to the grace given us. If one's gift is prophecy, let him use it in proportion to his faith" (Romans 12:4–6).

Common self-statements

- I was born stupid.
- Everybody is smarter than me.
- I cannot do school.
- I will always fail.
- Teachers gave up on me.
- I am an idiot.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either smart or dumb.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that I will always fail.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling slow and concluding I am dumb.
- Labeling: Calling myself dumb.

Challenging questions

- Who first called me dumb, and what did they know about me?

- What am I good at?
- How do I learn best?
- What help or accommodations exist?
- What does Scripture say about God's choices?
- Who sees my gifts?

Truth summary

> I am not dumb. I learn differently, I have gifts, and God uses people of all abilities. I can find the help and methods that fit me.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Pride
- Humility
- Gifts, Physical/Material
- Wisdom

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Love

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
Being known and cared for by God rests on His love rather than personal importance.

You Say — Lauren Daigle
God's loving assessment challenges identity based only on weakness or feelings.

Is He Worthy — Andrew Peterson
Honest recognition of a broken world can lead to hope in Christ's final restoration.

Jesus Loves Me — Gaither Vocal Band
This familiar hymn places confidence in Jesus' love rather than personal strength.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I'm dumb"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I'm dumb." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who first called me dumb, and what did they know about me?
- ☐ What am I good at?
- ☐ How do I learn best?
- ☐ What help or accommodations exist?
- ☐ What does Scripture say about God's choices?
- ☐ Who sees my gifts?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God chose the weak and foolish things.
- ☐ Ordinary people with Jesus do remarkable things.
- ☐ I have gifts for the common good.
- ☐ I am fearfully and wonderfully made.
- ☐ I learn differently.
- ☐ I can get help.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ 1 Corinthians 1:27
  "But God chose the foolish things of the world to shame the wise; God chose the weak things of the world to shame the strong."
- ☐ 1 Corinthians 12:7
  "Now to each one the manifestation of the Spirit is given for the common good."
- ☐ Acts 4:13
  "When they saw the boldness of Peter and John and realized that they were unschooled, ordinary men, they marveled and took note that these men had been with Jesus."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Gifts and help: Each week, note one strength used and one help sought.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, 1 Corinthians 1:27 becomes: "Sarah can write: "God chose the weak things of the world.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Self-Esteem, Low" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

These cards support emotional and spiritual care and do not replace medical care. Follow your doctor's advice about treatment and medication, and choose steps that are safe for your body. In an emergency call 911; for thoughts of self-harm call or text 988 (U.S.).

- [ ] List strengths. Write ten things you do well.
- [ ] Find your learning style. Try listening, pictures, or hands-on work.
- [ ] Ask for help. Tutors, coaches, or evaluators.
- [ ] Memorize 1 Corinthians 1:27. Say it when you feel dumb.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I'm dumb": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Gifts and help
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I'm dumb.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have been called dumb for so long. Show me my gifts, lead me to help that fits, and heal old wounds. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.